

Keegan Whitacre

The Ohio State University · Lab Manager & Research Associate

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EDUCATION

University of Florida

2025

B.S., Psychology · Minor in Anthropology

GPA: 3.93 Psychology · 3.86 Overall

HONORS & AWARDS

Outstanding Undergraduate Student Poster Award — Institute for Learning in Retirement 2025

National Merit Scholarship 2021–2025

Benacquisto Scholarship — University of Florida 2021–2025

Dean's List — University of Florida 2021–2025

PUBLICATIONS & BOOK CHAPTERS

Cogdill-Richardson, K., **Whitacre, K.**, & Bluck, S. (in press). Shaping the final story for family: Profiles of resilience. *Applied Cognitive Psychology*.

Lindquist, K. A., **Whitacre, K.**, & Shaback, H. (under review). The intersection of language and emotion across early development. In V. LoBue, K. Perez-Edgar, & K. Buss (Eds.), *Handbook of Emotion Development: Advances in Theory, Research, and Practice*. Springer Nature.

POSTERS & PRESENTATIONS

Whitacre, K., Feldman, M., Bonar, A., Ma, R., & Lindquist, K. (2026). *Examining emotion malleability beliefs as a moderator on associations between early life maltreatment and poor sleep* [Poster presentation]. Society for Affective Science Annual Meeting, Pittsburgh, PA.

Cogdill-Richardson, K., **Whitacre, K.**, & Bluck, S. (2026). *Shaping a final life story for family* [Presentation]. Institute for Learning in Retirement, Gainesville, FL.

Whitacre, K., Cogdill-Richardson, K., & Bluck, S. (2025). *Dignity therapy for older cancer patients: The role of early life stressors* [Poster presentation]. UF Cancer Center Research Showcase, Gainesville, FL.

Whitacre, K., Cogdill-Richardson, K., & Bluck, S. (2025). *Dignity therapy for older adults: Revisiting early life stressors* [Poster presentation]. Institute for Learning in Retirement / UF Aging Science Awards, Gainesville, FL.

Whitacre, K., Cogdill-Richardson, K., & Bluck, S. (2025). *Dignity therapy for older adults: Revisiting early life stressors* [Poster presentation]. PGSO Undergraduate Poster Forum, Gainesville, FL.

INVITED TALKS

Whitacre, K. (2026, June). *Mechanisms of dignity therapy* [Invited talk]. Palliative Care, UF Health, Gainesville, FL.

Whitacre, K. (2025, June). *Dignity therapy* [Invited talk]. Medical/Health Psychology Seminar, University of Florida Department of Clinical and Health Psychology, Gainesville, FL.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Affective Science Lab · The Ohio State University

Department of Psychology · Advisor: Dr. Kristen Lindquist

Lab Manager & Research Associate

August 2025 – Present

- Helped establish the Affective Science Lab at Ohio State following its relocation from UNC Chapel Hill, developing organizational, purchasing, communication, and research infrastructure from the ground up.
- Manage day-to-day laboratory operations, including research logistics, purchasing, supplies, digital systems, and coordination with university offices and external equipment vendors.
- Coordinated procurement and installation of approximately \$120,000 in psychophysiology equipment, including vendor communication, scheduling, and laboratory setup.

Interoceptive Pathways Linking Childhood Maltreatment to Adult Affective, Somatosensory, and Sleep Symptoms

Lead Author · 2026 – Present

- Lead a secondary-data study examining whether interoceptive distress and confusion mediate associations between childhood maltreatment and adult depression, anxiety, somatic symptoms, and sleep disturbance.
- Develop confirmatory parallel mediation models and exploratory analyses examining socioeconomic context, daily-life interoception, and momentary somatic-affective coupling.
- Develop an OSF preregistration of confirmatory hypotheses and the analysis plan, including primary and sensitivity analyses in R.

Early Life Maltreatment, Interoception, and Sleep Perception

2026

- Examined whether early life maltreatment was associated with discrepancies between subjective and objective sleep and whether emotion malleability beliefs and interoceptive awareness contributed to this association.
- Integrated maltreatment history, self-reported sleep, Fitbit-derived sleep measures, subjective emotional body awareness, and behavioral interoceptive accuracy in analyses of 135 adults.
- Presented findings at the 2026 Society for Affective Science Annual Meeting.

Respiratory Interoception Study

2026 – Present

- Contribute to development of a full experimental study of respiratory interoception, including sourcing and procuring physical components required to construct the research apparatus.
- Support study preparation through laboratory piloting of respiratory and other interoceptive paradigms and development of participant-facing recruitment materials.

Language and Emotion Development

2025 – Present

- Synthesized research published from 2021 onward on the intersection of language and emotion across early development, producing 5–6 pages of original literature synthesis from an initial conceptual outline.
- Contributed substantial original writing, literature review, and conceptual development to a collaborative handbook chapter under review with Springer Nature.

The Thriving Initiative · The Ohio State University

Collaborating PIs: Drs. Kristen Lindquist, Ken Fujita, & Jennifer Cheavens

Founding Member & Translational Associate

September 2026 – Present

- Collaborate with faculty investigators to build the research and administrative infrastructure for a university-wide initiative focused on translating psychological science into accessible community resources.
- Develop public-facing strategies for disseminating evidence-based behavioral science and promoting psychological well-being beyond clinical settings.

Life Story Lab · University of Florida

Department of Psychology · Advisor: Dr. Susan Bluck

Research Assistant · December 2023 – August 2025

Meaning and Stress in Early Life Project

February 2025 – November 2025

- Developed the project's focus on early life stress and meaning-making in Dignity Therapy narratives from more than 200 participants, leading to expanded analyses of individual differences in narrative responses.
- Led statistical analyses in R, including regression, clustering, and latent profile analysis, to identify resilience profiles and generate publication-ready results.
- Contributed to the development of the resulting manuscript, now in press at *Applied Cognitive Psychology*.

Meaning Making in Dignity Therapy Project

August 2024 – April 2025

- Collaborated on project development examining meaning-making within an existing Dignity Therapy dataset ($n = 202$).
- Drafted specific aims and abstract for a conference presentation and independently double-coded narrative transcripts.
- Conducted quantitative analyses in R.

Stressful Life Events in Dignity Therapy Project

January 2024 – July 2024

- Developed coding protocols and Excel-based data-management systems for identifying stressful life events across more than 140 Dignity Therapy transcripts.
- Double-coded narrative data and achieved interrater reliability of $\kappa = 0.81$.
- Co-developed a comprehensive coding manual and adapted the Holmes & Rahe Social Readjustment Rating Scale for narrative-research use.

Cognition and Decision Modeling Lab · University of Florida

Department of Psychology · Advisor: Dr. Peter Kvam

Research Assistant · August 2023 – March 2024

Timed Decision-Making Project

August 2023 – March 2024

- Conducted participant sessions for a timed decision-making study, including informed consent, computerized task administration, debriefing, and compensation.
- Assisted with participant walkthroughs of eye-tracking procedures and software during data collection.

CLINICAL & COMMUNITY EXPERIENCE

Alachua County Crisis Center

Gainesville, FL · May 2024 – Present

Hotline Operator

May 2024 – Present

- Completed 80+ hours of structured crisis-intervention training, including 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline certification.
- Provide crisis intervention, de-escalation, safety planning, and resource linkage on a 24-hour emergency hotline.
- Coordinate with law enforcement and inpatient facilities for emergency response when situations escalate beyond hotline scope.

Care Team Associate

2024 – Present

- Selected for the Mobile Response Team following 100+ hours of hotline experience.
- Deliver on-site risk assessment, safety planning, and de-escalation in collaboration with law enforcement and medical personnel.
- Provide trauma-informed, culturally responsive support and linkage to longer-term mental health services.

American Foundation for Suicide Prevention

Ohio Chapter · July 2025 – Present

Education Committee Member · Trained in *Talk Saves Lives*

Ohio Researcher Speaker Series

2025 – Present

- Coordinate a statewide research speaker series connecting suicide research with practitioners and community audiences.
- Facilitate dissemination of research addressing social, structural, and clinical contributors to suicide risk.

Education Committee & Community Outreach

July 2025 – Present

- Contribute to statewide educational strategy, curriculum review, and program planning for evidence-based suicide prevention initiatives.
- Support mental health education and resource dissemination across schools and community organizations.
- Represented AFSP at the 2026 Ohio Mental Health and Addiction Conference: *Inspiring a Stronger Tomorrow*, Columbus, OH.

The Ohio State University REACH Program

Columbus, OH · September 2026 – Present

Certified REACH Suicide Prevention Trainer

September 2026 – Present

- Certified to deliver the university's 90-minute REACH suicide prevention training to Ohio State students, faculty, and staff.
- Trained to teach recognition of warning signs, empathetic engagement with people experiencing suicidal thoughts, and connection to appropriate resources.

SOFTWARE & OPEN SOURCE

EMA Forge

2026 – Present

Primary Developer · emaforge.keeganwhitacre.com

Open-source framework for ecological momentary assessment and browser-based physiological measurement, including web-based photoplethysmography and an ecological adaptation of the Phase Adjustment Task (ePAT).

RESEARCH & TECHNICAL SKILLS

Methods & Analysis: Qualitative methods, content analysis, survey design, psychometric scale adaptation, interrater reliability, regression, ANOVA, clustering, latent profile analysis, longitudinal/experience-sampling methods, psychophysiological measurement, ecological momentary assessment.

Software & Programming: R, Python, SPSS, Microsoft Excel, C++, JavaScript.

Certifications: 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, REACH Suicide Prevention Training, HIPAA, IRB, FERPA, Cultural Competency, Responsible Conduct of Research (RCR), Human Subjects Protection (HSP).

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

Society for Affective Science

2026 – Present

Student Member